



BEFORE

Abraham Lincoln was elected the 16th U.S. President in November 1860. He won his votes entirely in the North, not being on the ballot in ten Southern states.

FINDING A GENERAL

On November 5, 1862, Lincoln **dismissed** [General George McClellan](#) (see [Organizing for the Fight](#)) as commander of the **Army of the Potomac**. Dissatisfied with many of his replacements, Lincoln's eye had finally fallen on [Ulysses S. Grant](#) of **Vicksburg** fame.

THE GREAT TASK REMAINING

On January 1, 1863, Lincoln issued the [Emancipation Proclamation](#), freeing enslaved people in **ten Confederate states**. Despite growing casualty lists and **rising antiwar sentiment** in the North, he was steadfastly dedicated to the war, which he declared in his [Gettysburg Address](#) as "the great task remaining before us."

On the evening of March 8, 1864, at a glittering White House reception, Abraham Lincoln had his first good look at its guest of honor, General Ulysses S. Grant. The short, slightly stooping figure was disappointing in appearance, except for his blue eyes, which to one army officer always suggested a man determined to drive his head through a brick wall. It was an expression that Lincoln welcomed.

Grant won battles. That was why Lincoln had now appointed him general-in-chief of all Union armies. Together they planned how to win the war that year. Grant advocated coordinated advances: south to Mobile; southeast to Atlanta, to cut off General Robert E. Lee's supplies; and a three-pronged advance on Lee himself—in his front, up through the Shenandoah Valley, and to his rear via a landing south of Richmond.

Lincoln's future in the balance

Much depended on the success of Grant's plans. Lincoln was facing a re-election battle, and his party had split over his policies. Hard-line Radical Republicans, convinced Lincoln had mismanaged the war and could not be re-elected, were decamping to the Radical Democracy Party or "Copperheads." This new party convened in late May in Cleveland, Ohio, and nominated the ever-popular soldier politician, John C. Frémont, for president. Republicans still